STOP ASKING FOR PERMISSION

LESSONS ON AMBITION, IDENTITY AND BECOMING



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AETHER

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This book shares personal experience and perspective. It is not medical, psychological or financial advice.

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Before We Begin

For most of my life I felt empty. I was born in Russia, went to a regular state school, moved to England, studied, made friends, hit the goals I was supposed to hit, and still felt like nobody was home. Until I was about twenty-one or twenty-two, I lived in victim mode. I blamed my family, my friends and my circumstances for the way my life felt, and it never occurred to me that I was the one holding the pen.

What changed things was not one big breakthrough. It was years of therapy, spiritual work and very uncomfortable honesty with myself. Slowly I stopped asking why things kept happening to me and started asking what I was going to do about them. I started acting on my creative impulses instead of waiting for a job or a friend group to fill the gap. I learned to disappoint people. I stopped apologising for my ambition. This book is what I learned along the way.

I wrote it because I keep meeting the same person in my comments and messages. You feel behind. You have been told you are too sensitive, too intense, too much. You have a feeling that you are meant for something bigger, and a life that keeps pulling you back into the program: the safe job, the expected path, the version of you that keeps everyone else comfortable. You are smart, often too smart for your own good, and you have probably thought about all of this far more than you have acted on it. If that sounds like you, this book is for you.

It is not for people who want to be told they are fine exactly as they are and should change nothing. I care about you too much for that. Some of what I say will feel harsh. Some of it you will disagree with, and that is fine. I would rather you argue with me than nod along and go back to sleep.

You can read this book in order or open it wherever you need it. Each chapter stands on its own, and each one ends with the lessons I most want you to keep. Read slowly. Notice which parts make you defensive, because those are usually the parts that matter most. And please do something with what you read. Insight without action is just entertainment.

We start with my story, how I went from empty to awake, so you know where all of this comes from. Then we look at identity, and why who you are is not a category you have to stay inside. From there we move to one of the hardest and most useful skills I know, which is learning to disappoint people. After that we go into the shadow, the anger, envy, ruthlessness and shame most of us were taught to hide, and why those parts of you hold so much of your power. Then I ask you to stop thinking and start doing, because overthinking is the most respectable way to stay stuck. We talk about karma, ego and the strength of your spirit, and what actually decides whether your talents turn into something real. We look at beauty, the body and validation, and why caring for yourself can be a spiritual act. And we finish with the system, and the fact that it is not coming to save you.

None of this is a promise that your life will look like mine, or like anyone else's. It is an invitation to stop asking for permission. Let's begin.

CHAPTER 1

My Story: From Empty to Awake

> The day I realised I was nobody was the day I finally got to choose who I would be.

The day I realised I was nobody

When I finished university, something strange happened. I looked at my life and understood that I was nobody. Not in a tragic way. In the most freeing way possible.

Up until then, every idea I had about myself came from the outside. Which school I went to. Which classes and activities I signed up for. Which university accepted me. Who my friends were, where I ranked in the unspoken hierarchy of my year, who liked me, who hated me, which boyfriend had just dumped me. That was my whole identity. A pile of rankings and reactions that I mistook for a personality.

Then school ended, and the structure that had been holding that identity together disappeared. What was left was a huge, uncomfortable emptiness. I knew I did not want to keep living the way I had been. The people and things that used to fill my days no longer interested me. Most of all, I knew it simply was not enough.

Here is what I want you to understand. That emptiness was not a problem to solve. It was a door. Once I saw that my self-image was just a construction, built from old chapters and old surroundings, I was free to drop it. And when you drop it, you can start choosing from an almost endless range of experiences instead of following a script.

Think about it. As a child you were your real self. Then your parents told you how the world works and how you should behave. Then school taught you who to befriend, how to act if you were popular, how to act if you were not, what to do after you got bullied. Layer after layer of rules that had nothing to do with you. Realising you are nobody lets you peel those layers off and reconnect with the impulses you had before anyone told you to be sensible. That is when you start to feel lit up from the inside, because you are no longer living out what your parents think is good or what your friends happen to be doing.

Empty, even when everything looked right

For most of my life I felt empty, no matter what was going on around me. The only exceptions I can remember were a few dramatic, intense teenage romances, which is not exactly a healthy source of meaning.

On paper, nothing was wrong. I had friends. I had nice clothes. I had an interesting education. I was achieving things. I even reached goals I had wanted for years, goals about how I looked, what I accomplished and who I was surrounded by. And I still felt hollow. I would go on holiday convinced that life was about to become amazing, then come home to normal life and feel low again.

The thing that finally ended that feeling was creativity. For years I believed creativity belonged to a certain type of person: the eccentric genius splashing paint across a giant canvas, the chaotic musician. I did not see myself in that picture. Then it hit me that I am one of the most creative people I know. It explained everything. The constant ideas. The vision. My love of art, music, drawing, public speaking, helping people and working with consciousness.

Only when I let myself act on those things, and actually put them out into the world, did I start to feel full. Not because anyone applauded. Recognition usually arrives later, after a long quiet stretch where nobody notices. I felt full simply because I was producing something from all the inspiration that had been stored inside me.

Before that, I was waiting. Waiting for a magical group of friends or a magical office job that would suddenly make me feel passionate and alive. Saying it now, it sounds almost funny. The answer was inside me the whole time. If you are waiting for a job or a crowd to rescue you from emptiness, I would gently suggest you stop waiting and start making something.

When I stopped trying to heal

I do not love the phrase "healing journey". I prefer self-discovery, because the better you know how you operate, what you are comfortable with and what you truly want, the better your life gets. But there was one moment in my story where healing is the right word, because I realised that continuing to "heal" was actually hurting me.

When I moved to London, I hit a crisis. I understood that I did not want most conventional careers. I did not want to apply for a normal job. For someone like me, who lives on momentum and change, that

realisation knocked me over. Improving, optimising and moving forward is my passion. It is close to an addiction, and I had been living that way for about three years.

So I did what a lot of people do now. I talked to ChatGPT about how bad I felt. It gave me the standard advice: not every day has to be special, you do not always have to be in motion, learn to appreciate an ordinary day. For a while I accepted it. I told myself I had a program in my head that said everything had to be exceptional, and that I needed to unlearn it.

The more I tried to convince myself that an ordinary life was fine for me, the worse I got. I let go, I stopped doing much, and I went downhill. I gained weight. I was at home disliking myself. When your energy stops moving, a lot of things in your body and mind stop moving with it. That was my experience, anyway.

Then it clicked. Change and self-improvement are my passion. Becoming exceptional is my passion. I do not want a day like everyone else's or a career like everyone else's. So why was I forcing myself to feel fulfilled by a life that simply did not fulfil me? I needed to get up and go.

That experience taught me something I want you to keep. There is a fine line between the parts of your early conditioning that hold you back and the parts that push you forward. Not every intense trait is a wound. A passionate lover who falls apart after a breakup might write the poem of their life. If they had smoothed out every bit of that intensity, the poem would never exist. Generic advice is built for the average person. If you are not average in temperament, use it carefully.

What I want you to take from this

- Your self-image is built from past environments, so you are allowed to rebuild it.
- Treat a period of emptiness as an invitation to rethink how you want to live, not as a failure.
- Stop following the scripts handed to you by parents, school and friends.
- Reconnect with the impulses you had as a child and act on them.
- Notice when reaching your goals still leaves you empty, and look at whether you are creating anything of your own.
- Stop waiting for a job, a partner or a friend group to make you feel alive.
- Do not force yourself to feel fulfilled by a life that does not fulfil you.
- Ask whether a strong trait is really a flaw to fix or a driver that moves you forward.

CHAPTER 2

Who You Are Is Not a Category

> You are not shy or outgoing, good or bad, cool or cringe; you are all of it, and that is exactly the point.

Stop shrinking yourself into a label

Most of us describe ourselves with a short list of opposites. I am shy, not outgoing. I am organised, not chaotic. I am the sensible one, the funny one, the quiet one. It feels like self-knowledge, but it is a fence. Every label you pick rules out the experiences that belong to its opposite.

I used to do this too. My ego liked a neat, narrow version of me because it was easy to protect. The moment I accepted that I could be calm and wild, disciplined and messy, deep and silly at the same time, my life widened. Different people and opportunities showed up, simply because I had stopped hiding the sides I had neglected.

One of the most limiting labels of all is "cool". Being seen as cool is a golden cage. It makes sense at seventeen, when looking effortless and a bit mysterious is the whole game. As an adult, it keeps you small. Picture a good-looking guy who was the most popular boy in his school. Imagine he has a hidden theatre-kid side. He can follow it and take the slightly embarrassing film role that everyone laughs at,

and that choice can open a huge career. Or he can stay the cool guy from his town, working somewhere stylish, admired locally, going nowhere. Growth often looks cringe from the outside.

The cousin of cool is nonchalance. Trying to seem niche, pretending you are not really trying, keeping your work small so a particular crowd approves of you. If you have something to offer, spread it as widely as you can. The goal is to reach as many interesting, like-minded people as possible, not to win a nod from one in-crowd.

There are two ways to live well. Be a naturally normal person who works the system, which is completely valid, or be an unusual person who fully owns it. The option that does not work is being unusual while pretending to be normal. Masking drains your energy, rarely convinces anyone, and builds your life on a foundation that eventually collapses. When people call you arrogant or too much, treat it as a filter. It is sorting the right people from the wrong ones.

This matters most for sensitive people. I think of it like an iceberg: most of what you are sits below the surface, and that depth is what lets you create things other people would not think of. Feeling lonely in a crowd usually means you are in the wrong crowd, not that something is wrong with you. Look further than your immediate circle.

Finally, protect your ideas about the future. I have never been someone who copies templates of what worked before. I have always looked ahead, and for years I was mocked for it, so I learned to keep my ideas quiet and play the always-happy, always-funny girl. That was one of the worst experiences of my life. Just never let conventional people talk you out of your gut feelings about where things are going.

Your ego is running more of your life than you think

If you want a fulfilling life, the first thing to study is your own ego and the defences it uses. A lot of people build their whole lives around those defences without realising it. Insecurity creates friend groups whose real purpose is to prove you are loved. A deep feeling of inadequacy creates careers chosen for status, and those careers burn people out because they were never about purpose. Admit your weak spots to yourself and they stop deciding for you.

One of the sneakiest defences is being "good". My whole life I believed I was the kindest, most understanding person around. I do have real depth, and I will not take that away from myself. But the truth was that I had learned to be good in order to be loved. Many of us did. Maybe you had to be the perfect student, or a parent's emotional support. If anger got you punished, you probably buried it and called yourself patient.

Anger is not a moral failure. It is a healthy reaction to a boundary being crossed. For years I was the therapist friend, and eventually I saw that I was giving so that people would appreciate me. So I quit that role. Now I would much rather be kind when I actually want to be, with no expectation of anything back, while allowing myself to be imperfect. People who do good things and then quietly resent everyone for not repaying them are not being noble.

The same pattern shows up in "playing dumb". My mom works in fashion, and she always told me that in a creative industry you meet people with all kinds of intentions, so just act normal and do not show you have noticed anything. I took that to heart for years. I clocked every weird vibe and every attempt to belittle me, then acted like I had seen nothing. It filled me with unprocessed emotion.

If you sense disrespect, do something with it. Step back, or say something. Do not let the fear of looking paranoid stop you from trusting what you perceive.

Understanding the ego also changes how you see other people. I no longer think in terms of good and evil. Jealousy and shadiness are usually ego mechanisms protecting someone from pain, and everyone, me included, carries both sides. So I choose my people by one thing: how self-aware and honest they are with themselves.

And be honest with yourself about what you want. Many people are ashamed of their wishes because family and friends have trained them to stay small. If you do not have a solid sense of identity, your goals are often borrowed from your parents and friends, which is exactly why they feel so hard to reach. They were never yours. Stop polling everyone about every choice. You are where you are because of your choices, which means you can make different ones.

From victim to adult

I lived in victim mode for most of my life. I hated my life until I was around 21 or 22, and I blamed everything: family, friends, circumstances. Victim mode sounds like "my parents want me to be this", "my friends laugh when I post my art", "people like me never get chances". The excuses are endless and comfortable, because if life is happening to you, nothing is your responsibility.

The warning sign is one question: why does this happen to me? As long as that question runs your head, your efforts will keep failing. Swap it for this: what can I do with what I have?

What changed it for me was realising I could simply leave. I could leave a job. I could leave friendships that took more than they gave. I could call certain relatives less often. With that power came a cost:

blowback. If you quit and your old colleagues talk about you, that is the price of choosing your own well-being, and it says nothing about your future. Progress was slow. I kept going anyway.

To me, this is the real difference between psychological childhood and adulthood. A psychological child feels powerless, stays in situations they resent and complains about them. A psychological adult knows they are in control. They walk away or set a clear boundary when they are mistreated. They leave jobs where they are not valued, take risks and own the outcome.

None of this means life stops being frustrating. There are still things, like immigration rules or my own family system, that can send me spiralling. But nothing I know is more empowering than taking responsibility.

There is a healthy kind of delusion that belongs here too. Believing boldly in your potential while taking focused, consistent action is a sign of high responsibility. The passive version, where you journal and wait for the universe to deliver, quietly hands your responsibility away and can waste years. Do the inner work on your fears so you become someone who can actually receive what you want, then go and get it.

Building confidence you can stand on

I think of confidence and identity as having three parts: making choices out of self-love, knowing yourself deeply, and having people around you who want you to win.

Self-love is practical. It means investing in your appearance, your health and your routines, and treating yourself with respect. It does not mean a night out drinking with friends; that is not self-care,

however often people call it that. It will feel artificial at first; keep going until it is normal.

Knowing yourself means real study. Look at the main traumas you carry, what your parents were like, what was passed down through your family, even the day you were born and the archetypes you seem to embody. I take esoteric systems seriously, which means going deep instead of reading three pages and labelling everyone. Learn what lights you up and what drains you. When you do this properly, traits you used to call laziness or a bad temper start to look like parts of a complex design that makes sense.

You also need spaces where you can be completely yourself. Time alone. Art, and noticing what it stirs in you. Your own ideas, creative outlets and projects. Social media and friend groups only give you a foggy reflection of who you are. Scroll less.

Confidence also comes from knowing your audience. I was born in Russia and went to a regular state school, where I was doing great socially. Then my parents fulfilled their dream of sending me to boarding school in England, and suddenly nobody was interested in me, including some people I found genuinely interesting. That stretch of rejection lasted about five years and taught me that I am not for everyone. By university I could recognise the types of people who would never click with me, and I stopped chasing them.

Then act. Confidence does not arrive with age or with some perfect moment. You build it by behaving like the person you believe you are: telling people your ideas, dressing like the person you are becoming, buying the thing you have wanted for years without spiralling into guilt.

Keep your discipline, but know that the hardest work happens in your mind. Clearing fears and limiting beliefs can take years. It took me more than five years of working with professionals to understand that my biggest wins came when I was relaxed and being myself, not when I was straining to impress anyone.

Choosing your people and playing the long game

When you are still building yourself, where you put your passion decides a lot. Everyone craves some drama and intensity. Most people waste it on messy relationships and friend-group conflict. You cannot afford to pour your creative energy into immature dynamics while you are still under construction. Notice where your intensity goes, and point it at your work.

Judge relationships by how people make you feel today, not by how long you have known them. That includes family. I love my parents, and loving parents can still unsettle your focus, because they grew up in a different time and may not understand what you are building. Are your conversations about gossip, or about growth and plans?

Look at people's trajectories, not snapshots. Most of the people I have met started with more advantages than I had, and I assumed they would go on to huge things. Very often they did not. Self-made people, the ones who built themselves through effort and through facing their darker sides, are a different calibre. In the same way, age is not wisdom. Some older people still think in very childish ways. Judge ideas on their merits, including mine.

Aim high, and accept that perfection is an illusion. Perfectionists move slowly and lose momentum. People who stop caring never make anything great. I live in between: always pushing, testing my

limits with a sense of play, and still letting myself feel satisfied with what I have done.

Expect fear. It shows up every time you leave your comfort zone, and it does not disappear with success. Fear is not a stop sign. It is evidence that you are doing something brave, and walking through it is how the old stuff finally leaves.

Last, do not quit early. When you find what is right for you, you will feel a kind of elation while doing it. Results come later. Disciplined actions pile up quietly until they cross a threshold, and then the payoff often arrives all at once. That delay is why so many people give up just before it would have worked.

What I want you to take from this

- Drop the fixed labels and let yourself hold contradictory qualities at the same time.
- Choose growth over looking cool, niche or effortless, even when it feels cringe.
- Either fit the system naturally or own your weirdness fully; stop masking.
- Study your ego, and check whether your friendships, kindness and career are defences or real choices.
- Replace "why does this happen to me?" with "what can I do?" and take responsibility for what follows.
- Build confidence by choosing yourself, studying yourself and acting like the person you believe you are.
- Pick people by how self-aware they are and how they make you feel now, not by history.

- Treat fear as a sign of bravery and keep going, because results arrive after the effort, not with it.

CHAPTER 3

Learning to Disappoint People

> The day you stop being convenient is the day you start becoming yourself.

The good person trap

I want to start with the people who will find this chapter hardest: the sensitive ones. The empathetic ones. The friend everyone calls when something goes wrong. If that is you, I need you to hear something that nobody told me early enough. Your emotional depth was not given to you so you could manage everyone else's feelings.

Most deeply sensitive people I know grew up in homes where they had to compensate for something. They had to be the understanding one, the mature one, the little adult who kept the peace. That conditioning teaches you a quiet lie: that your emotional intelligence exists to serve. So you become the mom friend, the perfect girlfriend, the coworker who remembers everyone's birthday and never asks for anything back.

It feels virtuous. It even gives you a sense of identity. But underneath all that overgiving, something else builds up. Resentment. Anger you are not allowed to feel because good people do not feel it. You end up hiding behind a "good person" identity that keeps you from ever meeting your own needs.

Here is the part people do not like to admit. People pleasing is not pure selflessness. A lot of it runs on a huge need for attention and a very low sense of self-worth. You give so much because being needed is the only way you feel valuable. I say that without judgment, because the way out starts with naming it honestly. Say it to yourself plainly: my self-worth is low, and I am also ambitious. I want to make things happen. Both are true at once, and neither is shameful.

Then do something practical. Write down the things that make you feel genuine self-love, the activities where you feel most like yourself, and do more of them. That is where you move from pleasing mode into creative mode.

Your range of feeling, including the darker parts like anger, aggression, and desire, is meant to fuel your own life. Your art, your business, your leadership, the space you take up in the world. When you stop pouring it into other people's emotional holes, you finally have it available for what you came here to build.

They love the vibe, not you

I will go as far as saying that learning to disappoint people is one of the most valuable skills you will ever develop. The reason is uncomfortable. Many people who are close to you do not love your growth. They love the version of you that is convenient, comforting, and entertaining to them.

I learned this in a very unglamorous way. At university I tore three ligaments in my ankle and had to disappear for three weeks of intensive therapy at home, trying to recover without losing the

semester. And nobody messaged. Nobody checked in. I could not go to parties or be the fun one in the room, so I simply stopped existing for most of the people around me.

That experience taught me something I now consider basic human nature, not evil. People are drawn to you when you are in your bright state: happy, funny, sharp, generous with your energy. When you are run down or being taken apart by life, most of them go quiet. A few people love you for who you are. Usually that means family, a partner, a friend who has been there for many years. Everyone else is attached to a chapter of your life and a shared interest. Value the few. Stop needing the many.

Once you see this clearly, something loosens. If someone's love depends on you playing a role, then disappointing them is not a betrayal. It is just the end of a performance. Picture someone who has studied psychology for years and one day decides she wants to become a musician. Her family will probably say they preferred the caring, sensible girl she used to be. Of course they did. That version was easier for them. It does not mean they know what is best for her.

So let people react when you stop following their script. Let them call you selfish. Change careers, cities, directions, even when the people around you disapprove. And stop going back to those same people for reassurance. Asking the people who prefer the old you to bless the new you is a losing game.

This is what healthy selfishness looks like. You stop measuring your worth by how many people approve of you, and you start prioritizing your own life.

Permission only comes from you

Most people are not living their real calling, and the main reason is not lack of talent. It is fear of upsetting their parents, their friends, their coworkers. As long as you need approval from those people, you will never fully discover what you are capable of. You will pick the career that sounds good at family dinners, the path that flatters your ego, the life that keeps everyone comfortable. And you will feel empty inside, even if it looks like success from the outside.

I call the alternative deliberate spontaneity. In each situation, ask yourself one question: what would I do right now if I simply did what I wanted? Then do that. Say what you really think. Act on what you feel. This is not the same as attacking people or picking fights with those who are not bothering you. It is a series of small refinements that slowly line your life up with who you want to become.

Notice the rule many of us carry: I must never upset or disappoint anyone. That rule compresses you into a narrow, society-approved version of yourself. Exceptional lives do not come from that version. They come from integrating the parts you usually hide, your impulses, your desires, your shadow, and asking what you would do if you could act freely. Judge your success by whether it reflects your real capacity, not by how much applause it gets.

I make my plans and decisions alone. I share them once they have become real. That is not secrecy for its own sake. It is because support almost always comes after results, not before. When you are riding a wave of conviction, the opinions of others can only slow you down. Then, once your decision shows up in the world, the same people say they always knew you had it in you.

The same goes for new ideas. When an idea arrives, it is a seed of pure energy. Be grateful for it and start developing it straight away. Do not run to your friends, parents, or mentors for a second opinion before you have committed. They do not share your vision, and their doubts can dilute something that was never theirs to judge.

And be careful whose advice you take at all. A lot of people quietly hate their jobs, their relationships, and their lives, and they will not admit it. Those are often the people giving advice. Of course they will not encourage you to take a big risk. Before you listen to anyone, including close friends and parents, ask whether they are living a life you actually want. Opinions from people on the edges of your life deserve even less weight.

Only you can give yourself permission. Nobody is coming to hand it to you.

Choosing your circle on purpose

As you grow, a strange thing happens. Many people become less appealing to you. That is not arrogance. It is what happens when you no longer need others to mirror back who you are. Once you have a strong identity, you stop accepting whoever is available and start looking for genuine resonance. You also notice how few people are aiming for anything big, and how many build their whole identity around news and politics, which I personally find draining. You do not need to change how they think. You can simply limit the contact.

Ask yourself an honest question about the people around you: would I be happy turning out like them? If the answer is no, that group might be a comfort blanket. Some people deliberately keep company

with those below their level so they can always feel like the standout. It feels safe, and it keeps you stuck. Look instead for people who inspire you and push you.

I think of it in terms of energy. Every person carries a kind of field, and the more inner work you do, the stronger it gets. Spending a lunch with someone at a very different level is fine. Spending most of your days compressing yourself to fit people who live in victim mode drains you, even if you are just sitting in the same room. This is why, in London, I avoid the tube when I can and walk or take the bus instead. Being packed into a space heavy with stress and misery affects me, and I take that seriously.

That brings me to victim mode, because it is the clearest line I draw. Some people believe reality simply happens to them. The economy, the ex, the boss, the family. Others take responsibility for their money, their relationships, and their development. Those people fail too, often painfully, but they also get to own their wins, and they treat every setback as a prompt for inner work. If you want to reach your goals, you will have to put distance between yourself and the first group, even when it means leaving people and environments you have known for years.

Big friend groups get harder too. Many of them run on ego, masks, and venting. If you regularly need to vent about a friend, that is not a bonding ritual. It is a sign your values do not match. When I give a friend advice and they do the opposite, that is their choice; it is not my business to control. But if their choices make me genuinely uncomfortable, I would rather end the friendship cleanly than keep complaining about it. Stop outsourcing your sense of importance to groups. The people who end up beside you at your goals are often strangers you meet along the way.

Life without the applause

Society rewards people who are manageable and reputation-focused. The moment you start acting with real autonomy, some of that support disappears. Authentic people inevitably become less likable to the crowd. Boundaries do that. So does refusing to bow to hierarchy for its own sake.

I do not feel inferior to anyone because of a title, a tenure, or a polished CV. Credentials and rank are mostly illusions designed to make people feel small. I judge people by how they think and act in front of me. I respect bravery, knowledge, and self-work at any age. And I leave groups that demand I conform to their rules.

There is a cost to this, and I want to be straight about it. Hardship on the way to your goals is not optional. A corporate path can pay you without much public scrutiny, but it often costs you your time, your freedom, and your self-expression. Build something visible and you will be criticized, sometimes by people close to you. Even the most successful people alive are mocked online every day. If fear of that keeps you small, it will set the ceiling on how far you go.

And please, never feel guilty about your own self-improvement. Every upgrade you earn comes from facing pain and discomfort that most people avoid: looking straight at the insecure, ashamed parts of yourself. Other people's struggles reflect their own choices and their relationship with themselves. Shrinking your progress or hiding what you have built will not help them. People who stay the same will often misunderstand your change. Let them.

The real skill is this: keep producing and keep showing up when nobody is clapping. Ground your determination in your own vision, not in other people's reactions. The applause, if it comes at all, comes late.

What I want you to take from this

- Your sensitivity exists to fuel your own life, not to service everyone else's.
- Name your low self-worth and your ambition honestly, then do more of what makes you feel self-love.
- Let people be disappointed when you stop playing the convenient version of yourself.
- Make big decisions alone and share them once they are real, because support follows results.
- Before taking anyone's advice, ask whether they are living a life you want.
- Ask whether you would be happy becoming the people around you, and choose your circle on that basis.
- Distance yourself from people who believe life happens to them, and own your own results.
- Keep showing up without applause, and never feel guilty for growing.

CHAPTER 4

Your Shadow Is Your Power

> Everything you were taught to hide is waiting to work for you.

Living in shame

For most of my life I believed I was weird, embarrassing, ugly, fat, and simply too much. When you carry that much internal shame, your whole existence turns into damage control. You spend your energy working out how to cancel out how terrible you think you are, and how to manage a facade so people will like you.

My inner critic was brutal. It talked down to me constantly. I lived almost entirely in my head: how do I look, do they like me, am I about to fail. I was the harshest judge of myself, and honestly of other people too. And the cruel part is that fixing things on the outside did nothing. I could improve my looks, improve my grades, go from no friends to dozens of them, and still feel exactly the same inside. Always dissatisfied. Always a step away from being acceptable.

If you recognize yourself here, please hear this: no external upgrade will fix internal shame. A harsh inner voice is not a sign that you are motivated. It is a sign that shame is driving the car.

What changed it for me was not a new achievement. It was sustained inner work. I spent around two years with meditation and intention-setting, working with a spiritual teacher, and one day in 2025 that work seemed to land all at once. I let go. I have always related to Nina in Black Swan, the character who is far too hard on herself. That day I found the other side, the part of me that moves freely, does what she wants, and does not care whether everyone likes her. I knew I was perfect in my imperfections, and I loved that about myself.

The biggest shift was physical. I stopped living in my brain and started living in my body. I want to be careful not to promise you anything, because everyone's path is different. But I can tell you what it was like for me. After roughly twenty-one years of living in my mind and caring about appearances, status, and hierarchy, giving myself full permission to be my whole self felt electric. A constant feeling like being in love, with no object. Energy that had nowhere to go except into creating. I genuinely felt an itch to make things, because suppressing myself was no longer an option.

I wish everyone could find that state early, before careers and families lock in heavy choices. Do not let fear stop you from finding out who you really are.

The traits you were punished for

Your shadow is not mysterious. It is mostly made of the traits you were shamed or punished for as a child. Anger. Lust. Selfishness. Authority. Anything that made the adults around you uncomfortable got pushed down, and what got pushed down did not disappear. It just went quiet and started running things from the basement.

When you repress those traits, you cling to a rigid self-image. "I am a good person." "I am the kind one." "I am never selfish." And that is exactly what makes you easy to manipulate. Anyone who wants something from you only has to suggest you are being unkind or selfish, and you fold, because that accusation threatens the only identity you allow yourself.

Integrating your shadow removes those hooks. Once you accept that yes, sometimes you are angry, sometimes selfish, sometimes reckless, the accusation loses its power. You do not owe anyone the management of their feelings. And you can choose to care only about the opinions of people you respect or are inspired by.

Take aggression. Society treats it as shameful. But aggression is the emotion that lets you act on your impulses, take up space, lead, and build. People who are cut off from it often end up in lives they never really shaped, and then they blame their boss or their family for it. Integrate that drive and point it at something personal and powerful.

Take envy. Most people would rather invent a story about why someone does not deserve what they have than admit they want it. I have always been honest with myself about envy, because I have always been very aware of my insecurities. I treated them as things to work on, never things to pretend away. That honesty is what pushed me to improve as a teenager, and it is why I rarely feel envious now. Envy is just information about what you want. Use it, then go back to your own path.

Take spite. People call it toxic motivation, and they tell you it needs fixing. I have spent around ten years in therapy and spiritual work, and I disagree. Pain inflicted on you works like a pressure chamber. It is awful while it lasts, but it expands what you can hold. After someone wrongs you, you have two paths. The victim path, where

you wallow and ask why it happened to you. Or the warrior path, where you get better. If wanting to prove someone wrong is what moves you forward, do not dismiss it. Use it.

And yes, ruthlessness. Being extra kind will not make everyone love you. I wish someone had told me that years earlier. Tell people directly when they speak to you in a way you will not accept. Cut off the people holding you back. Focus on your own ideas. Do what it takes to become who you want to be. I find that liberating, not cold.

Humiliation is training

I have been publicly humiliated many times. Some of it came from genuine mistakes. Some of it came from simply being myself in a way that did not fit what was considered cool or normal. And for a long time I also ran a private humiliation ritual, feeling mortified even when nobody was looking at me.

Before you have been through real humiliation, it feels like it might kill you. The fear sits in your body at an animal level, because underneath it is the old fear of being cast out of the tribe. Then it actually happens. And you notice that nothing happened. You did not die. A few people said a few things, usually people who are irrelevant to your life. That is when you see the fear for what it is: an illusion that has been quietly limiting your self-expression.

Each of those experiences made me more free, not more careful. That is the reframe I want you to take. Humiliation, shame, even betrayal can strengthen your spirit. People who have never faced them tend to be terrified of pain, change, and action. People who have survived intense shame become comfortable letting old versions of themselves die. Your past embarrassment becomes an anchor you can hold onto the next time something hard comes.

So do not let the fear of looking foolish stop you from starting the business, the blog, the project, or wearing the thing you actually want to wear. Ignore judgment from people who have no real place in your life.

The same goes for being called arrogant. If you have been through hardship and rebuilt yourself, you will hear it eventually: self-centered, full of yourself, main character energy. Do not let it shake you. Many people saying it have not faced what you faced, and people who avoid discomfort often try to pull others down to their level. To build anything, you have to be the main character in your own life.

Ego in disguise

Not everything that feels like confidence is confidence. Sometimes ego hides fear, and it is worth learning to tell them apart.

Take the feeling of being above something. Sometimes it is accurate. You have genuinely outgrown a friendship, a relationship, a job, and staying is keeping you tied to an old version of yourself. Leave. But sometimes "that is beneath me" is fear wearing a nice outfit. I see talented people who refuse to promote their work because self-promotion feels cheap. Or who dismiss social media, or an opportunity like modeling, as unserious. If you make something, sell it. A route is a route.

The savior complex is another disguise. It looks generous. You pour your wisdom into people who are not ready to change, again and again. But often helping others is just a safe way to avoid exposure. It lets you skip the rejection and the perfectionism that come with building something of your own. Your wisdom is better spent creating your own work.

Then there is being palatable. Many people are embarrassed to be good at things, so they shrink their talents to seem easier to like. Especially if you are starting your passion later in life, without the child prodigy story, you need to integrate your animal side, the part that is hungry and assertive. Admit to yourself that you want more than the people around you. Own your power openly and accept that some people will like you less for it.

And honestly, some of us are attached to suffering. It feels deep. Yearning and feeling misunderstood happen in a dreamy inner world where everything is dramatic and meaningful. Happiness, by comparison, looks boring. It asks for repetitive work and full responsibility for your own life. Results are slow. But if you move your imagination from wallowing to building, step by step, you start making something real.

The same energy shows up on a night out. The bold, funny, charismatic, sexy version of you that appears after a few drinks is not the alcohol. It is a part of you that you normally suppress because you have been taught not to be too much or draw too much attention. Let that version show up sober. Put that drive into goals that will matter in fifteen years, not just into the weekend.

When it is time to burn it down

There is a stage that looks like success from the outside. For about a year and a half to two years, I was in an environment where I was doing well by every normal measure. People liked me. I had great grades. I was planning a career. But I could not be my full self there. I could not fully express my will, my power, or my real personality.

When you are living like that, something in you eventually asks for change. For me it arrived like a storm. I found myself burning bridges and walking away from old scripts. Part of it felt conscious and part of it felt like a force I could not control, dismantling the structure of my life. I woke up one day a different person.

The lesson I took from it is that we usually think of only creation as sacred. Destruction can be just as divine. Sometimes the next level requires tearing down old attachments, comfort zones, validation loops, and patterns. And sometimes it requires letting go of your old reputation entirely.

If your life looks good but your real talents are going unused, notice it. If you cannot be your whole self where you are, expect pressure to build. And when the old structure starts to fall, do not rush to hold it up. That might be the most honest part of your growth.

What I want you to take from this

- No amount of external improvement will fix shame; do the inner work instead.
- Find the traits you were punished for as a child, because that is where your power is hiding.
- Accept that you can be angry, selfish, or reckless at times, so guilt trips stop working on you.
- Use aggression, envy, and spite as fuel instead of treating them as something to be ashamed of.
- Let each humiliation make you freer, not more careful.
- Check whether feeling above something is really fear, and promote what you make.

- Bring your bold, charismatic self into everyday life and point that energy at long-term goals.
- Allow old versions of your life to fall apart when it is time to level up.

CHAPTER 5

Stop Thinking, Start Doing

> Your ideas are not worth anything until your hands start moving.

The real price of anything good

Let me tell you the least glamorous secret I know. The thing that sits underneath both success and happiness is the same skill: the ability to sit inside bad feelings, bad reactions and bad events without letting them run you.

When you look at someone who seems to have blown up overnight, you are looking at the last frame of a very long film. You see the money, the attention, the lifestyle. You do not see the years of being told no. You do not see the family members laughing at the idea of their business, their music, their little brand that nobody believed in. You do not see the gigs where nobody turned up and they had to perform anyway. You do not see the posts that sat there with no likes for months.

That is the actual job. Not the vision board. The job is staying in the room when it is embarrassing to be there. Your belief in what you are building has to be louder than the shame of being seen trying. If it is not, the shame wins every single time, because shame is very good at its work.

Happiness works the same way, which surprised me. I used to think happy people were simply lucky, or born with a sunnier wiring. What I see now is that happy people let negative emotions move through them instead of setting up camp inside them. They feel the sadness, the jealousy, the irritation, and they let it pass, because they know it is weather and not climate. Happiness, for me, has become a discipline. A choice I make again in the morning, and again in the afternoon when the morning version wears off.

And here is what I want you to understand about creating your reality: it is not something you do once a year with a journal and a candle. You are creating it every day, in every ordinary hour. I try to build a life where I feel genuinely excited about each day, and I treat improving myself like a game I enjoy playing, whether that is my fitness, my style or my skills. The sign that I am on the right track is not some big win. It is feeling joy in a boring moment, on a quiet walk, while making tea. When the mundane starts to feel good, bigger things are usually on their way.

Thinkers stay stuck, doers move

I am going to say something that might sting. A lot of very clever people live very small lives.

I have met so many people who live almost entirely in ideas, ethics and arguments. They can explain the economy, critique every business model, tell you exactly why your plan will fail. And they are broke, frustrated and convinced the world is unfair. Meanwhile, someone they consider less intelligent is out there building something, making money, living well. The thinker calls it luck. I call it fair. The other person focused on what they could actually do today, and then did it.

The difference between people who win and people who lose is not intellect and it is not luck. It is action. And the part people get wrong is where the ego lives. We assume the loudest person, the one posting and performing and putting themselves out there, has the biggest ego. In my experience, the biggest ego belongs to the person who keeps planning and never starts. Their real priority is protecting the image of someone who could do it. As long as they never try, they never fail, and the fantasy of their potential stays intact.

At seventeen or eighteen, that kind of cool detachment can earn you social points. Being too relaxed to care looks attractive at school. But by twenty five or thirty, the same nonchalance quietly eats your chance to build anything. Nobody is impressed by potential that never left the notes app.

So check where your energy goes. If most of it stays in your head, as research, planning, debating, imagining, then your ideas are living a better life than you are. Pull one of them out into the real world this week, even in a clumsy, unfinished form.

The cage of needing proof

I spent many years hiding what I actually thought. I could sense things, know things, feel things that I could not justify with a study or a spreadsheet, and every time I said them out loud, someone would rush to correct me. So I learned to keep quiet. I adjusted myself to fit conversations that were much smaller than I was.

I am done with that, and I want you to be done with it too.

Some people are so devoted to logic that they live tense, joyless lives. No flow, no pleasure, no spontaneity. I see it in my comments all the time: someone finds a tiny gap in what I said, or a missing

exception, and treats it like a victory. My message is not for them. It is for the people it lands with, and I am not going to water it down to cover every possible caveat for a person who was never going to listen anyway.

Demanding proof for every belief keeps you in a mental cage. If you will not trust your own experience until a researcher confirms it, you have handed your inner authority to strangers. When someone throws a study at you to make your lived experience disappear, you are allowed to stay put. Your own discoveries count. They are a valid way to grow, even if nobody has written a paper about them yet.

Part of what keeps people locked in is the ego's need to look educated. I know this one personally. I have always been hungry for knowledge, and for a long time I believed that the more I knew, the more successful and happy I would become. Then I started doing real inner work, studying myself and all sorts of esoteric systems, and something shifted. Intellectual achievement lost its grip on me. I still read, but now I read for pleasure and so I can share good things with other people. I no longer measure anyone by their degrees. I notice their inner development, because no amount of reading can hide the level of consciousness a person is operating from.

None of this means your mind is useless. Your mind is brilliant at awareness and structure. Use it to track your patterns, notice your emotions, plan your week, hold your boundaries and keep your discipline. Just do not let it hold the veto on your life. The mind steers toward what is familiar, and what is familiar is often built on old shame and old failure. It is very good at producing noble-sounding reasons to stay exactly where you are. Your feelings and your body often point toward growth that your mind cannot explain yet. Let them have a vote.

Manifesting is not the same as moving

I have been practicing manifestation for about eight years. I usually got what I asked for. And yet, until fairly recently, I lived with a constant hum of anxiety. I felt like a nobody who was about to get crushed, even while I was meditating and visualizing every day.

It took me a long time to see why. Manifestation on its own is passive. You write the intention, you picture it, you repeat it, and then you wait for the universe to deliver. Our thoughts do shape our reality, I believe that completely. But if you stop there, you quietly put yourself in the position of a speck of dust waiting for big forces to act on your behalf. You lose your agency, and losing your agency feels like fear.

The real question is simple. If you want to become a singer, an athlete, a founder, are you living like that person right now? Are you acting on the impulses that pull you toward it? Acting on your impulses is what actually changes your identity. Manifestation can be the starting point. It cannot be the whole method. And if you notice yourself feeling anxious while doing all the right spiritual practices, take it as a sign that you are not taking enough action.

The same goes for affirmations. Saying "I am rich and loved" into the mirror does very little if your subconscious believes the opposite. I think of those deep beliefs as software with bugs in it. If the code says you are not enough, that you lack, that you are powerless, then your life will keep producing evidence for that code no matter what you say out loud. The repeating experiences in your life are clues. The same kind of relationship, the same money problem, the same rejection: that is the program showing itself.

Affirmations also bounce off you when you are in defense mode, gripping your comfort zone and protecting your ego. Real change asks for deeper work. You have to look at your limiting beliefs, your trauma responses, and the shadow, those hidden, uncomfortable parts of yourself you would rather not meet. When you do that work, something changes. Your intentions stop being words you recite and become something you feel in your body. That is when they start to work.

What I want you to take from this

- Expect rejection and embarrassment behind anything worth building, and keep showing up anyway.
- Treat happiness as a daily discipline and let hard emotions pass through you instead of moving in.
- Notice when your energy stays in planning, and turn one idea into real action this week.
- Recognize that refusing to try is often your ego protecting an image of what you could do.
- Trust your own experience and intuition without waiting for proof or permission.
- Use your mind for awareness, structure and discipline, but do not let it veto new paths.
- Treat manifestation as a starting point and act on your impulses so you keep your agency.
- Do the deeper work on your subconscious beliefs and shadow, because affirmations alone cannot rewrite them.

CHAPTER 6

Karma, Ego and the Strength of Your Spirit

> Pain will either shrink you or grow you, and you are the one who decides which.

Your spirit decides what your talent becomes

Everyone arrives with talent. I really believe that. Some of us come in as creative visionaries, some as careful, analytical builders, some as natural teachers or connectors. Those gifts are like seeds. On their own, they are just potential. What turns a seed into something real, something useful and beautiful that exists in the material world, is the strength of your spirit.

When I say strength of spirit, I mean something very specific: your tolerance for discomfort. That is it. Not your confidence on a good day, not your talent, not your connections. How much discomfort can you hold and still keep walking?

The most actualized version of you does not show up on a smooth road. It shows up after trials, after experiences that genuinely hurt. Every one of those moments hands you a choice. You can let the pain break you. You can turn the pain into your new identity, and let it compress you, make you bitter, make you a victim. Or you can turn it into strength and use it as fuel for the next step.

I know the victim option very well. I lived there until I was about twenty one or twenty two, and it felt like the truth at the time. But it is a dead end. The people with strong spirits are simply the ones who keep saying yes to the next challenge. The ones who keep saying no do not usually crash. They plateau. They stay talented and stuck at the same time, which might be the saddest combination there is.

Let go of people, places and the roles they gave you

Here is a perspective on attachment that changed my life. Most of the people and experiences that come into your life are there so that you can meet a new part of yourself. A relationship, a close friendship, a city, a friend group: each one creates a unique field between you and it, and in that field a side of you comes out that you had not met before. Sometimes it is a funny, flirty, confident side. Sometimes it is a terrifying fear of abandonment. Either way, that part of you is what you get to keep. The person or the place was the doorway.

We have been sold an idea of unconditional love that we expect from partners and friends. In my view, it mostly does not exist there. The only truly unconditional love I see is between a mother and her newborn, and between you and yourself. When you become your own caregiver, when you take proper care of yourself and make decisions from self-love, you have found it. And that love has to include all of you: your strong, magnetic side and your flawed, insecure, messy side. You need to love both, because you have both.

Non-attachment protects you in two ways. First, it makes you much harder to manipulate. When you are desperate to keep something, you will betray yourself to hold on to it. That is how people end up staying with partners who treat them badly. Second, it keeps you

moving. I have watched so many people give up on a dream because of a hometown boyfriend or a best friend they could not imagine leaving behind. Love people fully, but do not let them become the walls around your life.

Sometimes non-attachment goes further, and I want to be honest about that. If you have not found your purpose and you feel like you are not living up to your potential, you may need a period of isolation. You may need to step away from the friend group you are in right now.

The reason is that the people around you have given you a role. You are the funny one, the hardworking one, the gym person, the daughter who does what she is told. Your family has its version of you and your friends have theirs. Over the years those roles pile up into layers of identity that are not really yours. This is how I felt for most of my life: sitting in a room full of people, playing my part, and feeling completely empty inside.

If that sounds familiar, pay attention to it. Notice the roles you play. Ask yourself whether they reflect who you actually are. Then be willing to be alone for a while, without those mirrors, so you can finally see yourself as no one in particular. That is uncomfortable, and it is the first step.

Ego, soul and what you are really chasing

The phrase ego death sounds dramatic, so let me put it simply. Ego death is the moment you realize that every negative trait you judged in other people also lives inside you. The arrogance that annoyed you, the neediness, the vanity, the anger. It is all in there.

What surprised me is the second half of that realization. The traits you suppressed hardest are often your best qualities in disguise. The "arrogance" you buried might be your self-belief. The "vanity" might be your love of beauty. The anger might be the force that finally makes you set a boundary. Start by noticing what you judge most often in others, then ask what it would look like as a strength in you.

This connects to how you pursue success. There is success that comes from the ego and success that comes from the soul, and they feel completely different from the inside. Ego-driven success has a particular inner dialogue. It is always ranking. Am I impressive? Am I above them? What will people think of my title? It is built on emptiness, which is why no amount of it ever feels like enough.

Soul-driven momentum feels physical. It is like having an internal power source switched on. You are not defining yourself by job status or other people's opinions; you are moving because the energy is coming from within you. So listen to how you talk to yourself about your goals. If the voice is mostly about impressing people, you have found the ego. Go looking for the work that energizes you even when nobody is watching.

Karma, receiving and taking responsibility

People misunderstand karma constantly. Karma is not a cosmic judge handing out rewards and punishments. It is cause and effect. Actions have consequences, and your life reflects the level of consciousness you act from.

People who hurt others are usually operating from low states like shame and fear. Their lives tend to mirror that state back to them. Sensitive people who actually process their pain do something different: they expand. They grow from what happened to them.

That is why I do not think revenge is necessary. You do not need to arrange anyone's downfall. Their patterns will deliver the results. Your job is to process your own pain deeply and keep growing.

Something else I have noticed is that the timing is not the same for everyone. Many people who exploit or emotionally abuse others are running unconscious programs. They often do not see what they are doing, and they pay for it slowly, through isolation or declining health over years. If you are a highly aware person, the rules are stricter. You do not get to make cheap, sneaky moves. When I try anything petty, life checks me almost immediately. So I have stopped trying. I would rather make bold, truthful moves and own the consequences than play dirty and get caught by my own awareness.

Responsibility also shows up in how you receive. I think outcomes depend a lot on whether you are receptive or entitled. Receptivity means following your path, creating real value through your art, your teaching or your business, and trusting that money, recognition and support will follow. Entitlement sounds like "why me" and endless blaming of the government, the system, the economy. Chronic complaining is a lack mindset, and it closes doors.

And if your life keeps leaving you feeling used or drained, look underneath. Often there is a subconscious belief that you are not allowed to have needs, wants or a path of your own. Those fear-based beliefs quietly pick your career and your community for you. They tell you opportunities do not exist and everyone struggles. You end up shrinking to fit groups that never matched you. Nobody else can rewrite that for you. The good news is that you can.

What I want you to take from this

- Build your tolerance for discomfort, because that is what turns your talent into something real.
- Turn each painful experience into strength instead of letting it become your identity.
- Treat relationships as doorways to new parts of yourself, and become your own caregiver.
- Notice the roles others have given you, and be willing to spend time alone to see past them.
- Look at the traits you judge in others and ask how they might be strengths in you.
- Check whether your drive comes from wanting to impress or from energy within you.
- Treat karma as cause and effect, skip revenge, and make bold, honest moves you can own.
- Stop complaining, create real value, and work on the beliefs that say you cannot have what you want.

CHAPTER 7

Beauty, the Body and Validation

> Your body is not a project to punish; it is the home your whole mission lives in.

Wanting to be beautiful is not the problem

Before anything else, I want to say clearly that what follows is my personal experience and my perspective. I am not a doctor or a nutritionist, and nothing here is medical advice. If you have health concerns, talk to a qualified professional. What I can offer is the story of how my relationship with my body changed, and what I believe about why.

I do not think wanting to be beautiful is shallow, and I am tired of it being demonized. Caring about how you look is not the issue. How you go about it is.

I think of it as two different kinds of beauty routine. The first one I call patriarchal, and it is the one most of us grew up with. It is consumerist. It tells you to buy endless creams and serums, book procedures, pay a fortune for classes, and force yourself into a shape. Underneath, it runs on detachment and quiet self-dislike. You treat your body like a problem to be fixed from the outside, and every purchase confirms that you are not good enough as you are.

The second I call matriarchal. It is about connection and nourishment from the inside, using simple things that are easy to find. For me that looks like a daily massage with body oils, keeping my feet warm in soft socks, and drinking teas I make from herbs and spices I like, such as cinnamon, cardamom and rose. None of it is fancy. What matters is the message underneath: I am taking care of you, you are safe. Warm feet, in particular, make my whole body feel calmer.

What changed when I stopped punishing myself

I have struggled with my weight and with shame about my body for a long time. I tried everything. I was always obsessed with improving myself, and for years that meant the hard version: tracking macros, chasing high protein targets, restricting, pushing through workouts I hated.

Eventually I dropped all of it. I stopped tracking. I started eating varied food that I actually wanted and that felt nourishing to me: stews, herbs, lots of different things, still including meat because I feel better with it. I kept moving, but in a way I could stick to, a short home workout of around twenty five or thirty minutes that I can tolerate even though I will never be someone who loves exercise. And I added rituals that had nothing to do with burning anything: oils on my skin, baths, rubbing my feet.

The result, for me, was the opposite of what the punishment mindset promised. My body got leaner and more defined than it ever was when I was restricting. My self-esteem went up. My cycle felt healthier. I felt more connected to my body than I had in my life. I am not telling you that this will happen for you or that you should eat a certain way. I am telling you that for me, the turning point was stopping the punishment.

What I learned is that the thing I was really fighting was not my body. It was my need for control.

Most people fall short, I think, because the logical mind is trying to control everything: how you look, how your relationships go, how much you produce. That part of the mind is primitive. It was shaped by childhood fears, and it believes that if it monitors everything closely enough, nothing bad will happen. But constant monitoring cuts you off from your body. You stop feeling what you actually need right now because you are too busy checking the numbers. So ask yourself honestly where you are a control freak. Then practice letting a little spontaneity in. Let the unpredictable happen sometimes. Bring your attention back to your body and what it is asking for today.

Repression is exhausting

Here is something I wish I had understood years earlier. A lot of the tiredness I felt was not about sleep. It was about holding myself in.

When you do not let yourself express what is inside you, your ideas, your ambitions, your opinions, your emotions, that energy does not disappear. It circulates with nowhere to go. In my experience it turns into static: anxiety, doubt, that loop of "I am nothing, I cannot do this," mixed with a deep longing to be bigger. And then you wonder why you are drained all the time. The energy is there. You are spending it on suppressing yourself.

Most of that suppression is in service of other people. We hold back so that parents, siblings, friends, colleagues and bosses stay comfortable, and so that the image we have built stays intact. Every

time you do that, you betray yourself a little, and your body feels it like a circuit that cannot close. It is as if you are squeezing your whole being into a tiny tube.

The way out is not complicated, though it is scary. Say what you think. Stop spending energy maintaining an image. Give your trapped ideas and emotions an outlet, whether that is creating, speaking, building or simply telling the truth in a conversation where you would normally smile and nod.

I have come to believe something similar about fragile health more broadly. Some people seem to run on endless energy whatever they do. Others, and I count myself among them, feel low energy, foggy or unsettled whenever they live by other people's expectations. My view is that if your health is fragile, your path is closely tied to knowing where your energy goes and following your inner voice. Notice when you need rest. Notice when you feel angry or disappointed. Notice when you simply do not want to do something: the party, the person, the career path, the course your parents keep pushing. Saying no to what is not yours is a form of self-love.

My own struggles with weight started to ease when I stopped betraying myself and began following how my body felt. I do not think diets and wellness products alone can fix something that is emotional at its root. For me, my physical state has always been tied to whether I feel emotionally safe and whether I am living honestly.

Enjoyment is the spiritual practice

I see caring for my body as part of my spiritual path, not a distraction from it. Feeling beautiful and at home in your body is a deeply spiritual state, because it lines up your inner creative impulse with your physical form. Your body is part of your mission. When you

treat it with respect, on your own terms and according to your own needs rather than standards someone sold you, your inner growth speeds up.

That also means embracing the way you look. Your face and your body are an expression of who you are, a kind of personal archetype. You are not supposed to look like everyone else.

There is a huge misconception that a spiritual woman is endlessly calm, selfless and uninterested in money or pleasure. That is pop spirituality, and it gets things backwards. In my experience, the highest point of a woman's spiritual growth is enjoyment. It is falling in love with being in your body and with how it feels to be you. It is taking the energy you have, cultivating more of it, looking after yourself, and pouring it into something beautiful. The keyword is enjoy, not live in your head.

For a few years as a young woman I was liked by almost everyone. I had lots of friends and people thought I was fun and a great member of the community. I was not happy. All that approval gave me was a vague sense that I was probably doing fine.

Which brings me to validation. Women get mocked for wanting male validation, while seeking constant validation from friends and parents is treated as normal and even healthy. I do not think it is. A mature adult makes major decisions from their own intuition. Your best friend and your parents do not know you better than you know yourself. If you feel you have to run every choice past your friends to prove the friendship is close, or if your friends expect to be consulted before you decide anything, that is codependency, not love. Make the decision. Tell people afterwards if you want to. Your body, your life and your choices are yours.

What I want you to take from this

- Stop punishing and restricting yourself as the route to looking good, and choose care you can sustain.
- Pursue beauty through connection and nourishment rather than self-dislike and endless spending.
- Notice where you are a control freak and let your body, not the numbers, guide you.
- Treat chronic tiredness as a possible sign that you are holding yourself back, and find an outlet.
- Say no to events, paths and people that are not yours, even under family pressure.
- See caring for your body and enjoying your life as part of your spiritual path.
- Make your major decisions from your own intuition instead of waiting for anyone's approval.

CHAPTER 8

The System Is Not Coming to Save You

> Nobody is going to hand you a life worth living, so stop standing in the queue for one.

The template is ending

I want to start with something that might sting. If you feel behind, you probably are. Not behind your friends, not behind the people from school posting promotions and engagements. You are behind the version of you who is already using their talents, already building, already showing the world what they can do. That gap is real, and the feeling of time running out is your body telling you the truth about it.

Most people treat that feeling as anxiety to be managed. They breathe through it, they talk themselves down, or they go and ask someone older for perspective. And the older person usually says something comforting: take your time, I drifted for a few years, then I found a job and it all worked out. What they rarely say is that the job they drifted into was dull and meaningless, and that they stopped asking whether it fulfilled them a long time ago. I am not saying this to be cruel. I am saying that their advice belongs to a world that no longer exists.

That world had a template. You studied, you got a graduate job, you climbed a ladder inside an institution that was supposed to be there forever. When I started university I genuinely believed the most impressive thing I could do was land a job at an investment bank or a fund. Today I would turn that job down even if it came with no interview and a huge starting salary. Not because I am above money, but because a rigid routine designed by someone else suppresses everything natural in me. My energy rises and falls. Some days I am on fire and some days I need to be quiet. A life built around a fixed schedule asks me to ignore all of that, and I am no longer willing to.

Here is the uncomfortable part about AI. Everyone is scared it will take office jobs, and some of it will. But a job has always been a construct, and for a long time it gave status and income to people who had very little inside them. You could follow the process, sound strategic in meetings, and rise without a single original idea. AI is going to strip away the templates and the credentials those people relied on. What will be left is what you actually bring: your skills, your ideas, your taste, your ability to build something useful. So stop complaining about it and start preparing. Plan your life as if the stable nine to five is not an option, because for many of us it already isn't. And do not assume that leaving the office world means a worse life. It might be the first time your life is actually yours.

Build your own thing

I believe self-employment is the better path for most people, and the reason is less about money than about how it changes your mind.

When you are employed, you think about money in a loop. You get paid, you pay your bills, you count the days until the next payment. That loop does not change much with salary. Someone earning a little and someone earning a lot can both live inside the same

paycheck mindset. When you work for yourself, something else happens. You realise you are in a game, and that your choices lead to outcomes. You do not know exactly where your money will come from in a few months, and that sounds frightening until you notice what it really means: the options are wide open. The question stops being "when do I get paid" and becomes "what could I create from what I have?"

It also frees your identity. In a job you are a title. You are the accountant, the manager, the assistant, whatever the org chart says. Working for yourself, you can earn from several skills at once and become a person with many dimensions instead of one label. If you have read the earlier chapters, you know how much I hate being put in a box. A career can be the biggest box of all.

Think about a really gifted creative person. They have vision, they spot trends early, they have spent years studying art, film, books and symbols until their eye is trained. If they follow the usual route, they apply to a fashion brand, a gallery or a museum, and they end up on a salary somewhere around thirty thousand a year. That is barely enough to live in a flat share. Then, inside that institution, their ideas pass through layers of approval until whatever was special about them is watered down.

Now picture the same person making their own product and putting it in front of people on social media. Their instinct goes straight into the work. Nobody has to sign it off. They might struggle at first, but they are building something that belongs to them. I am not promising it will work out. I am saying you do not need an institution to tell you that you are valid. You were never waiting for their permission. You only thought you were.

The shame they sold you

So why don't more talented people do this? In my experience, it is not a lack of ability. It is embarrassment.

Most people would genuinely rather stay broke and empty than be seen trying something new. They would rather keep a job that barely covers rent, with no idea where they will be in five years, than risk someone from school watching them start a business or post their first awkward video. That fear tells you nothing about your idea. It tells you how much the people around you value comfort and safety. Their opinions come from that place, so they should not get a vote on your life. Early awkwardness is simply what starting looks like. Think in ten years, not in ten comments.

There is a story going around that content creation is low-status, shallow and a bit shameful. I have watched what some kids are fed on YouTube, and I understand why people feel that way. But that story has a side effect. It keeps the most intelligent, creative and visionary people sitting in their rooms, feeling too good for an ordinary job and also too good to put themselves online. That is ego, and it leaves you with no income and no influence. Clever people tend to doubt themselves the most, and that self-doubt is very easy to exploit. In a few years everyone will be sharing their work online. You can start now, or you can start later, when it is crowded and you are the one catching up.

I know this from the inside. For as long as I have lived in England, people have called me vain, narcissistic, try-hard. And I do try hard. I want to win. I want to look different and better every year. I work on my skills, my knowledge and my looks out in the open, because in this era nobody finds you if you hide. Waiting to be discovered is not a strategy. If someone thinks they are above self-promotion and

self-improvement, they are free to choose the safe road, retire tired, and wonder where the years went. I would rather be mocked now and have built something real later. Ridicule is the price of playing the long game.

You will also meet a particular kind of doubt, and in my experience it is very common in the UK and across Europe. You tell someone what you want to build, and the first thing they ask is how that is even possible, or where the money is going to come from, or who you think you are. A lot of people here are used to waiting for an institution to fix things: a petition, a pay rise, a reform. Doing things with their own hands and their own voice feels foreign to them. If you are someone who just goes and does the thing, treat that as a rare skill. Protect it. Do not let their questions slow you down.

Will beats privilege

It is fashionable to say privilege decides everything. I disagree. Money at the start is useful, but it is not the same thing as the spirit and mindset that build something lasting. A parent who can hand you a large sum to start a business is giving you capital. They are not giving you the ability to stay calm when everything is falling apart.

When people envy someone with wealthy parents, what they are really imagining is themselves, exactly as they are now, with more money. But you would not be you if you had grown up that way. If you grew up around struggle, you learned early how to keep going when things were hard. That is training. Honour it instead of pitying yourself for what your parents could not give you. And yes, do the healing work on what that upbringing left behind. I spent years in therapy and spiritual work for exactly that reason. Healing the wound and respecting the strength it built are not opposites.

I think the coming years will reward people almost like natural selection. Many people raised in total comfort have connections and very few interesting ideas, and they have never had to rebuild themselves. Doing something new and exceptional is rare for them. The real leverage now is a strong mind and a strong will. That means continuing when the odds look bad. It means putting your idea out there when it feels unpopular. It means keeping going when your numbers are small, when nobody seems to care yet, when you feel humiliated or ashamed. And it means ignoring the people who use the economy or the news as a reason you should give up. There will always be a reason to wait. The people who make it are the ones who stopped listening to those reasons.

The system was never designed to save you. That is not a tragedy. It is the moment you stop waiting and start building.

What I want you to take from this

- If you feel behind, treat it as a real signal and measure yourself against your potential, not against your peers.
- Plan as if the stable nine to five is gone, and look for your opportunities outside traditional institutions.
- AI will expose what each person actually contributes, so invest in real skills, ideas and the ability to build.
- Working for yourself turns money into a game of choices and lets you earn from more than one skill.
- You do not need an institution to approve your talent; you can make your own product and show it to people yourself.

- Embarrassment about trying, posting or promoting yourself is not a reason to stop; the critics are mostly protecting their own comfort.
- A hard start can be training, not a sentence; heal the wounds and respect the strength they built.
- Your will to keep going through doubt, low traction and other people's excuses is the leverage that matters most.

A Last Word

If you have made it this far, you already know what I am going to say. Nobody is coming to give you permission. Not your parents, not your friends, not your boss, not the system, and not me.

Look back over what we have covered. Your identity is not a category. The people who love the convenient version of you will be disappointed when you change, and you can let them be. The parts of you that you were taught to hide, your anger, your envy, your hunger to win, are not flaws to fix but energy to use. Thinking will not get you there; doing will. The strength of your spirit decides what your talents become. Your body is part of your mission, not a project to punish. And the old templates for a good life are falling apart, which means the space to build your own has never been wider.

All of it comes back to one thing. Your life changes when you stop waiting to be chosen and start choosing.

I know how easy it is to read a book like this, feel fired up for a day, and then slide back into the program. I have done it myself more times than I can count. So I am not going to ask you to transform your whole life by Monday. I am going to ask you to do one thing this week that the old version of you would not have done. Post the thing. Have the conversation. Leave the situation that keeps draining

you. Start the project you keep describing to people instead of making. Say no to something you were only going to do to keep someone else comfortable.

It will feel awkward. You might be embarrassed. Some people will not like it. That is not a sign you are doing it wrong. It is usually a sign you are finally doing it at all. Results lag behind effort, so keep going when it seems like nothing is happening. The payoff tends to arrive later than you want and faster than you expect.

Be honest with yourself about what you want. Feeling behind is not a verdict; it is information. Use it.

If you want to work through any of this with me directly, I offer one-on-one sessions and chart and purpose reads. They are there if they help. You do not need them to start, though. You have had everything you need to start for a while now.

So stop asking for permission. Go and become who you already know you are.